

Executive Interview Thesis

Build the company to carry the promise.

The actual work

Convert founder-led demand into a professional-services operating system that reliably sells, staffs, delivers, proves, renews, and learns - with humans and AI agents managed as one accountable capacity model.

The founder should remain the source of market signal.
The founder should stop being the routing layer.

Central contradiction

Remain bespoke enough to produce consequential client outcomes while becoming repeatable enough to forecast, staff, price, improve, and scale.

Operating partner posture

Success appears in retained clients, controlled margin, credible forecasts, stronger managers, dependable agents, and fewer routine founder escalations.

Economic lens

Utilization, realization, scope change, staffing mix, agent cost, delivery variance, renewal, margin, billing, cash, and bench readiness must reconcile.

Change burden

Document enough of the work to price, transfer, evaluate, and improve it without creating bureaucracy that outruns client value.

Six operating contracts

01 **Commercial promise**

Measurable outcome, decision owner, assumptions, acceptance evidence.

02 **Scope**

Included work, exclusions, client obligations, change triggers, price sensitivity.

03 **Capacity**

Pipeline confidence, human-and-agent mix, seniority, utilization, ramp, contingency.

04 **Run**

Weekly visibility for schedule, scope, quality, adoption, readiness, and escalation.

05 **Evidence**

Client acceptance, operating result, capability transfer, economics, and traceability.

06 **Learning**

What changes the next proposal, price, staffing model, agent, and method.

First-Year Operating Scorecard

Metrics with decisions attached

Retention · Delivery · Forecast · Leverage · Cash

Client retention

Questions: Did the client accept the result? Is renewal tied to documented value?
Signals: outcome acceptance, sponsor confidence, renewal probability, reference readiness.

Delivery integrity

Questions: Are schedule and scope holding? Is margin risk visible early?
Signals: milestone variance, utilization, realization, change requests, escalation aging, rework.

Forecast credibility

Questions: Do pipeline, staffing, revenue, margin, billing, and cash tell one story?
Signals: stage conversion, handoff quality, booked-to-bill, forecast-to-actual, capacity coverage.

Founder leverage

Questions: Which decisions still require founder involvement, and why?
Signals: founder escalations, attention hours, decision latency, reopened decisions, exception recurrence.

Agent capacity

Questions: Is each agent dependable enough for the work assigned?
Signals: task success, human override, evaluation pass rate, exception rate, latency, unit cost, owner review.

Bench and onboarding

Questions: Can the firm staff ahead of demand without carrying idle cost blindly?
Signals: time-to-productivity, skill coverage, weighted demand, utilization floor, hiring lead time.

Evidence-to-role transfer

AI-first operations	Vape-Jet transformation across operations, systems, telemetry, support, quality, and engineering flow
Agentic work design	DudeWorth frameworks for context, human authority, evaluation, escalation, governance, adoption, and time-to-value
High-velocity cadence	Amazon mechanisms protecting approximately five million second-day orders annually
Quality and technical translation	Compunetics execution across engineering, manufacturing, quality, customers, and high-reliability programs
Distributed commercial operation	Cardinal's first remote regional operation with CRM, fulfillment, logistics, and customer workflow modernization

Operating rule: A metric earns a place in the weekly review only when it changes a decision, owner, threshold, or next action.

Weekly operating review architecture

PORTFOLIO Which engagements changed posture?	ECONOMICS Where did scope, utilization, margin, billing, or cash move?	CAPACITY What demand can the current human-and-agent bench carry?	EXCEPTIONS What crossed a threshold, who owns it, and when does it close?	LEARNING What changes the next proposal, staffing plan, price, method, or agent?
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Executive Conversation Map

Questions, entry sequence, and fit

Founder + COO

Questions worth answering

1. Where is founder involvement value-creating, and where is it compensating for an absent mechanism?

2. Which client outcome most reliably predicts renewal, and who signs that it was achieved?

3. Where do proposal assumptions most often break during delivery?

4. What is the current unit of capacity: person, role, pod, workflow, agent, or blended model?
5. Which utilization or margin number is trusted least, and what conflict causes the distrust?

6. What can sales promise without delivery review? What should require one?

7. Which AI agent would the team miss tomorrow, and which creates more confidence than evidence?

8. What decision should the COO own independently in the first month?

120-day operating sequence

0-30 · Read Map engagements, economics, founder dependency, agent capacity, scorecard definitions, and operating truth.	31-60 · Stabilize Install the engagement record, sales-to-delivery review, scope thresholds, forecast reconciliation, and executive contract.
61-90 · Build capacity Pipeline-weighted bench, remote onboarding, manager standard, agent-management standard, and renewal evidence ritual.	91-120 · Release Run recurring operations beneath the founder, test forecast and economics, and select the next evidence-backed agent redesign.

The affirmative fit

The role asks for an operator who can connect client work, sales handoffs, economics, distributed teams, AI systems, and founder leverage. Russell's record is strongest at exactly those boundaries. The confidential firm's specific utilization model, client portfolio, and P&L mechanics must be learned directly; the immediate contribution is the operating discipline and technical fluency to make those mechanics visible, trusted, and actionable.

I am strongest where a company needs both operating discipline and enough technical fluency to make AI part of the work without mistaking automation for accountability.

Stakeholder topology

Founder / CEO market signal and strategic relationships	Client sponsors outcome acceptance and renewal	Sales team promise quality and pipeline truth
Engagement leaders scope, delivery, escalation, evidence	Finance / people margin, cash, utilization, bench	Agent owners job, eval, authority, cost, release

First working session

Take one recently completed engagement and reconstruct the load path: original promise, scope assumptions, staffing and agent mix, turning points, escalation, actual economics, client acceptance, renewal decision, and what changed in the next proposal. The goal is not a post-mortem. It is a reusable operating record.

Sources: supplied job description; MDC Executive Search public LinkedIn company page (accessed July 21, 2026).